T. W. Rhys Davids — Milindapañha, Book IV, Dilemmas 6 and 21 (1890–94)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Thomas William Rhys Davids (1843–1922), who carried the *Questions of King Milinda* into English nearly whole, and stopped — twice — at the threshold of the body. The mountain was his; this work has only carried the last two stones up.

The author's own terms

Meṇḍakapañha, Book IV's own name, means “the horned questions”: dilemmas horned at both ends, each horn a saying of the Buddha. In Dilemma 6 Nāgasena names the four doors into the womb — by karma, by kind, by family, and by invitation.

The story

Thomas William Rhys Davids was born on 12 May 1843 at Colchester, Essex, son of a Welsh minister, and schooled at Brighton and at Breslau, where he took up Sanskrit under Stenzler. He entered the Ceylon Civil Service in 1864, served as district judge, and, posted up-country with no teacher at hand, learned Pali from the Venerable Yātrāmulle Unnānse and the palm-leaf

libraries. Lord Chalmers's eulogy dates that service 1864–72; he left it in the early 1870s and was called to the Bar in 1877. In 1881 he founded the Pali Text Society — the 1911 Encyclopaedia Britannica gives 1882, a dissent carried here — and ran it for forty-one years, to render accessible “the rich stores of the earliest Buddhist literature now lying unedited and practically unused,” in his own words. By 1922 it had printed more than 25,000 pages. He held the Pali chair at University College, London, from 1882 and the Comparative Religion chair at Manchester from 1905 (Britannica: 1904). He married his student Caroline Foley and died at Chipstead on 27 December 1922, his Pali–English dictionary with William Stede unfinished.

The work and what survives

The *Milindapañha* records King Milinda, the Indo-Greek Menander of second-century BCE Sāgala, debating the monk Nāgasena; in Book IV each dilemma sets two sayings of the Buddha against each other for Nāgasena to resolve. Rhys Davids translated eighty of the eighty-two dilemmas of Book IV, omitting the sixth and the twenty-first. His Contents step silently from the fifth dilemma to the seventh, and from the twentieth to the twenty-second; his Introduction discusses a quotation from the Sela dilemma, so he had read it and still stepped around it. His reason is not recorded; any modesty motive is inference, carried as inference here.

Dilemma 6 (Trenckner pp. 123–130) sets the rule that conception requires three things together against the conceptions of Sāma and Maṇḍabya by a thumb's touch on the navel, resolved through the four doors. Dilemma 21 sets “Restraint of the body is good” against the Buddha's showing Sela the mark concealed in its sheath; Sela saw, Nāgasena answers, a counterpart made by psychic power, seen by him alone. The folders disagree on Dilemma 21's opening page — pp. 167–170 against pp. 168–170 — and neither is printed here as settled. His eighty stand whole, in the public domain, in Sacred Books of the East vols. XXXV (1890) and XXXVI (1894); the folders supply only the missing two, Englished fresh from his own base text, Trenckner's Pali of 1880, to drop into Book IV in its order. Horner's complete *Milinda's Questions* (1963–64) and, on the folders' record, Heim's (2025) stand in copyright — checks only, never copy-text.

Its English fortunes

No complete English rendering of Dilemmas 6 and 21 outside the copyrighted complete versions (Horner 1963–64; Heim 2025) was found after research; Bhikkhu Pesala's abridged *Debate of King Milinda* renders both dilemmas incompletely.

On that corrected footing, the slimmer folder's verdict survives only in its bounded form: this pamphlet is, to the editor's knowledge, the first free, public-domain-complete rendering of the Rhys Davids Milinda. The check was bounded: Pesala's two were not measured page by page in this run, and no WorldCat search for other partial renderings was run.

What completing it would take

Two checks remain. Dilemma 21's opening page, 167 against 168, must be settled against Trenckner's page images, and a Pali reader must collate the translation against them: the fuller folder flags one rendering, “rasmiyo nivasenti,” as resting on imperfect scan OCR and uncertain, and both folders note the abbreviation pe expanded in brackets. Until then they stand honestly flagged, completing the free classic in form while verification waits.

Sources

- Fuller folder (base text): `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/rhys-davids-milinda-two-dilemmas/rhys-davids-milinda-two-dilemmas.txt`
- Slimmer folder (sources list mined): `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/milindapanha-two-dilemmas/milindapanha-two-dilemmas.txt`
- PIN: `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-milinda.md`
- SBE XXXV, editor's notes and contents: http://93beast.fea.st.user.fm/files/section1/milinda/Questions%20of%20King%20Milinda%20(1).pdf
- Chalmers eulogy: http://discoveringbuddha.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/03/Thomas-William-Rhys-Davids-1843-1922-Eulogy-by-Chalmers-1922.pdf

- 1911 Britannica entry: https://www.studylight.org/encyclopedias/eng/bri/t/thomas-william-rhys-davids.html
- Milinda Panha contents: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Milinda_Panha